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LOSING CONTROL

The Strategic Air Command had been at DEFCON 2 readiness since the morning of October 24. At any moment there were as many as seventy-two nuclear-armed B-52 planes in the air on the “Chrome Dome” mission: in case of a nuclear attack on the United States, they would strike Soviet targets in retaliation. The pilots and planes were assigned twenty-four-hour shifts. Joining the B-52s in the skies were KC-135 Stratotankers, ready to refuel them in flight. B-47 Stratojet bombers of an older design were dispersed at airfields throughout the United States to preclude the possibility that most or all of them might be incapacitated by a Soviet first strike.[1]

SAC was prepared to fight a nuclear war, while its creator and now United States Air Force Chief of Staff General Curtis LeMay was ready to invade Cuba. On the morning of October 27, at a meeting of the Joint Chiefs of Staff in the Pentagon conference room, known since World War II as the “tank,” LeMay seized the initiative by proposing to draft a formal